EST

EXPLORE SKARDU TOURS

*Discover Skardu, Experience Nature.*

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

# General Office Standard Operating Procedure

Skardu, Gilgit-Baltistan, Pakistan

Deliverable 2 – Startup Launch and Business Development (Academic Assignment)

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| **Document ID** | EST-OPS-SOP-001 |
| **Version** | 1.0 |
| **Effective Date** | 21 October 2026 |
| **Status** | Draft for Academic Project Review |

**ACADEMIC PROJECT NOTICE**

Explore Skardu Tours is a **proposed** tourism startup created for an academic project. All office hours, leave allowances, role titles and procedures in this document are **proposed project assumptions**. They are not legal requirements and not verified facts. Applicable employment and other legal requirements must be checked before any real-world implementation.

# Document Control

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| **Version** | 1.0 |
| **Effective Date** | 21 October 2026 |
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## Version History

| Version | Date | Description of Change | Prepared By |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1.0 | 21 October 2026 | Initial draft issued for academic project review | Documentation & Compliance Coordinator |

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## Key Terms Used in This Document

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **Company** | Explore Skardu Tours, the proposed tourism startup. |
| **SOP** | Standard Operating Procedure. |

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| **Employee** | Any full-time, part-time, contract, seasonal or intern staff member working for the Company. |
| **Supervisor** | The Department Supervisor responsible for an employee's daily work. |
| **Field duty** | Work done outside the office, such as guiding, site visits, vehicle coordination or client pick-ups. |
| **Proposed assumption** | A figure or rule chosen for this academic project that must be reviewed and confirmed before real use. |

# 1. Purpose

The purpose of this SOP is to set out clear, simple and consistent office rules for Explore Skardu Tours. A small tourism startup works with tight deadlines, seasonal pressure, travellers from many backgrounds and frequent changes in weather and road conditions. Written procedures help the Company to:

- give every employee the same, clear expectations for attendance, conduct and communication;
- protect the Company's reputation for reliable, honest and respectful service;
- make sure client bookings, payments and personal information are handled carefully;
- support the health and safety of staff in the office and on field duties;
- reduce misunderstandings by recording decisions, approvals and responsibilities; and
- provide a fair way to raise concerns and deal with problems.

This SOP supports the Company tagline, **"Discover Skardu, Experience Nature."**, by building a professional and responsible workplace culture.

# 2. Scope

This SOP applies to all people who work for or on behalf of Explore Skardu Tours, including:

- the Owner and the CEO;
- the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager;
- all Department Supervisors and their teams;
- the Documentation & Compliance Coordinator;
- full-time, part-time, contract and seasonal employees, and interns or trainees; and
- anyone working from the Company office, from a field location, or remotely on official duty.

## 2.1 Departments Covered (Proposed Structure)

> **PROPOSED PROJECT ASSUMPTION**
> The department names below are proposed for this academic project. A real startup may combine or rename them depending on its size.

| Department | Main Activities |
|---|---|
| **Tour Operations** | Itinerary planning, guides, drivers, transport and accommodation coordination, field supervision. |
| **Sales and Marketing** | Customer enquiries, bookings, quotations, social media, website content, partnerships. |
| **Customer Support and Bookings** | Booking confirmation, client communication, feedback and complaint handling. |
| **Finance and Administration** | Payments, invoices, petty cash, office supplies, records and filing. |
| **Management Team** | Owner, CEO, HR / Sales / Marketing Manager and Documentation & Compliance Coordinator. |

Where a rule in this SOP conflicts with applicable law, the law must be followed and the SOP must be updated at the next review.

## 3. Roles and Responsibilities

The table below sets out the main responsibilities of each role. Job titles are used consistently throughout this document. No individual names are assigned in this draft.

| Role | Key Responsibilities |
|---|---|
| **Owner** | Provides overall direction and final authority over the Company.<br>Approves this SOP and any major changes to it.<br>Receives escalated matters that involve the CEO or senior management.<br>Makes sure enough resources are available for safe and lawful operations. |
| **CEO** | Leads daily management and carries out the Company's plans.<br>Approves this SOP together with the Owner and enforces it.<br>Approves leave for the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager and Department Supervisors.<br>Decides on serious corrective actions after a fair process. |
| **HR / Sales / Marketing Manager** | Is the Document Owner of this SOP and reviews it at least once a year.<br>Manages recruitment, induction, attendance review and leave records.<br>Receives and manages workplace complaints and conflicts.<br>Leads sales and marketing activity and supports other departments. |
| **Department Supervisors** | Assign work, set deadlines and monitor performance in their teams.<br>Check attendance, approve routine leave and report absences to HR.<br>Make sure safety rules are followed in the office and on field duties.<br>Raise problems early with the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager. |
| **Employees** | Follow this SOP, lawful instructions and Company policies.<br>Arrive on time, record attendance honestly and report absences promptly.<br>Treat colleagues, clients and partners with respect.<br>Protect Company property and confidential information.<br>Report hazards, incidents and suspected misconduct without delay. |
| **Documentation & Compliance Coordinator** | Prepares, updates and stores this SOP and related forms.<br>Maintains version control and the master list of documents.<br>Keeps attendance, leave, meeting and training records in an organised way.<br>Checks that records are complete and tells management about gaps.<br>Tracks legal and licensing requirements to be checked by management. |

## 4. Office Timings and Availability

> **PROPOSED PROJECT ASSUMPTION**
>
> All timings in this section are **proposed project assumptions**. They are not legal requirements. Actual working hours, weekly rest days, public holidays and break entitlements must be checked against applicable employment law and confirmed by management before real use.

### 4.1 Proposed Office Hours and Working Days

| Item | Proposed Arrangement |
|---|---|
| **Working days** | Monday to Saturday (Sunday is the proposed weekly rest day). |
| **Standard office hours** | 9:00 AM to 5:00 PM, Monday to Thursday and Saturday. |
| **Friday hours** | 9:00 AM to 5:00 PM, with an extended break for Friday prayers (see 4.2). |
| **Public holidays** | The office is closed on public holidays notified by the relevant authority. Dates to be confirmed each year. |
| **Peak tourist season** | Hours may be adjusted by the CEO with advance notice because of higher booking volumes. Any change must follow applicable law. |

### 4.2 Proposed Breaks

- A meal and prayer break of one hour, normally between 1:00 PM and 2:00 PM.
- On Fridays, an extended break of about two hours from 12:30 PM to 2:30 PM so employees can attend Friday prayers, with working time adjusted by the Supervisor as needed.
- Short rest breaks are allowed, as long as client enquiries and phone lines are still covered.
- Employees must not leave the office unattended during working hours without telling their Supervisor.

### 4.3 Punctuality and Availability

- Employees should be at their desks and ready to work at the start time.
- During office hours, employees should be reachable by phone, official email or the Company messaging group.
- Client messages and enquiries should be acknowledged as soon as possible, with a proposed target of the same working day.
- Employees should not make personal calls or use social media for non-work purposes during working time, except for short urgent matters.

### 4.4 Special Arrangements for Tourism Field Duties

Tourism work cannot always follow fixed office hours. For field duties, the following proposed arrangements apply:

- Field duty schedules, including start time, location and expected return, are set by the Supervisor and shared in writing (message or email) in advance.
- Employees on field duty record their start and finish times on the field duty log instead of the office attendance register.
- Time worked beyond normal hours must be approved by the Supervisor. Compensation, if any, will follow Company policy and applicable law, to be confirmed by management.
- Early starts or late returns caused by weather, road closures or client needs must be reported to the Supervisor as early as possible.
- Where practical, employees should receive a rest day or adjusted hours after a long field assignment, as approved by the Supervisor.
- A staff member must remain contactable by phone whenever mobile coverage permits. If coverage is poor in remote areas, the team must agree a check-in time before departure.

# 5. Attendance and Punctuality

## 5.1 Recording Attendance

- All office-based employees must record their arrival and departure time every working day in the attendance register (paper or digital sheet).
- Employees must record only their own attendance. Recording attendance for another person is misconduct.
- Field duty employees complete the field duty log as described in Section 4.4.
- The Documentation & Compliance Coordinator collects attendance records weekly and files them securely.

## 5.2 Late Arrival

> **PROPOSED PROJECT ASSUMPTION**
> The grace period and the actions in the table below are proposed for this project only.

| Situation | Proposed Action |
|---|---|
| **Arrival up to 15 minutes late (grace period)** | Record the actual arrival time. No action unless it becomes a pattern. |
| **Arrival more than 15 minutes late** | Inform the Supervisor before the start time where possible and give a reason. The late time is recorded. |
| **Three or more late arrivals in one month** | Supervisor holds an informal discussion with the employee and notes the outcome. |
| **Repeated lateness after discussion** | Referred to the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager under Section 14. |
| **Delays caused by weather, road closures or emergencies** | Considered fairly by the Supervisor. The employee must report the cause promptly. |

## 5.3 Absence Notification

- An employee who cannot attend must inform their Supervisor by phone call or message **before the start of the working day**, or as soon as reasonably possible in an emergency.
- The employee should state the reason, the expected length of absence and any urgent work that needs to be covered.
- Absence without notice is recorded as unauthorised absence and handled under Section 14.

## 5.4 Supervisor Responsibilities

- Check the attendance register daily and follow up on any unexplained absence.
- Arrange cover for urgent tasks, such as client calls or tour departures.
- Send a weekly attendance summary to the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager.
- Apply attendance rules fairly and consistently to all employees.

# 6. Leave and Absence Procedure

**PROPOSED PROJECT ASSUMPTION**

The leave types and allowances below are **sample figures for academic purposes only**. They are not legal requirements. Actual leave entitlements must be set according to applicable employment law and the employee's contract before real use.

## 6.1 Proposed Leave Types

| Leave Type | Proposed Allowance (Sample) | Notice and Evidence |
|---|---|---|
| **Annual leave** | To be confirmed by management | Written request at least 7 days in advance. |
| **Casual leave** | To be confirmed by management | Notify Supervisor in advance where possible. |
| **Sick leave** | To be confirmed by management | Notify on the first day. Medical certificate may be requested for longer absence. |
| **Emergency leave** | As approved case by case | Report as soon as possible. Details provided on return. |
| **Unpaid leave** | At management's discretion | Written request and approval before the leave starts. |
| **Public holidays and religious occasions** | As notified by the relevant authority | Dates confirmed by management each year. |

## 6.2 Planned Leave Procedure

1. The employee submits a **Leave Request Form** (paper or email) to their Supervisor, stating dates, type of leave and a contact number.
2. The Supervisor checks team workload, bookings and tour schedules, then approves, rejects or suggests different dates.
3. For leave longer than five working days (proposed), approval from the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager is also needed.
4. The decision is communicated to the employee in writing, ideally within two working days of the request.
5. The HR / Sales / Marketing Manager records the approved leave in the leave register.

During the peak tourist season, leave requests may be limited to keep enough staff available. The Company should explain such limits to employees in advance.

## 6.3 Emergency Absence

- Inform the Supervisor as soon as possible by phone, followed by a short message for the record.
- Provide a Leave Request Form or written explanation within three working days of returning (proposed).
- If the Supervisor cannot be reached, contact the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager.

### 6.4 Approval Authority

| Employee Group | Approves Leave |
|---|---|
| **Employees** | Department Supervisor (and HR / Sales / Marketing Manager for longer leave) |
| **Department Supervisors** | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager, with CEO approval for longer leave |
| **HR / Sales / Marketing Manager** | CEO |
| **CEO** | Owner |

### 6.5 Leave Records

- Leave Request Forms, approvals and the leave register are kept by the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager and filed by the Documentation & Compliance Coordinator.
- Employees may ask to see their own leave balance at any time.
- Records are kept securely and shared only with people who need them (see Section 13).

## 7. Dress Code and Professional Conduct

### 7.1 Dress Code

- Employees should wear clean, neat, modest and professional clothing that suits Pakistani and local Balti cultural norms. Traditional dress such as shalwar kameez is welcome.
- On Fridays and other agreed days, a more relaxed but still respectful dress may be allowed by the CEO.
- Employees on field duty may wear practical outdoor clothing, such as sturdy shoes, warm layers, rain gear and sun protection, suited to terrain and weather.
- Company-branded clothing or an identity card should be worn when meeting clients or representing the Company, if provided.
- Clothing with offensive slogans, images or political messages is not permitted.

### 7.2 Professional Conduct

- **Respect:** Treat all colleagues, clients, drivers, guides, hotel staff and partners politely, regardless of rank, gender, ethnicity, religion, language, age or disability.
- **Honesty:** Give accurate information to clients and colleagues. Do not make false promises about tours, prices or services.
- **Integrity:** Do not accept gifts, commissions or favours from suppliers or clients that could affect your decisions. Report any such offers to your Supervisor.
- **Discipline:** Follow lawful instructions, meet deadlines and avoid disruptive behaviour.
- **Representation:** Remember that employees represent the Company in public, on social media and during tours. Do not post confidential or damaging information.
- **Substances:** Alcohol, illegal drugs and tobacco or similar products must not be used at work or during field duty, in line with local law and Company policy.

### 7.3 Prevention of Harassment and Discrimination

Explore Skardu Tours is committed to a workplace free from harassment, bullying and discrimination.

- Harassment, including unwelcome comments, gestures, messages, touching or pressure of a sexual nature, is not acceptable.
- Bullying, threats, humiliation, shouting or spreading rumours are not acceptable.
- Discrimination in hiring, work allocation, promotion or treatment, based on gender, religion, ethnicity, language, disability or similar grounds, is not acceptable.
- Employees may report concerns to their Supervisor, the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager or, if the concern involves them, the CEO or Owner, as set out in Section 14.
- No employee will be treated unfairly for making a report in good faith.

*Before real-world use, the Company must check applicable law on workplace harassment and on the formal committee or procedure that may be required.*

## 8. Office Cleanliness and Shared Spaces

### 8.1 Desk and Work Area

- Keep your desk tidy. Remove food, cups and loose papers at the end of each day.
- Lock away confidential documents, cash and valuables when leaving your desk for long periods and at the end of the day.
- Shut down computers and switch off lights, fans and heaters when leaving the office.

### 8.2 Waste Disposal

- Use the bins provided. Do not leave rubbish on desks, windowsills or floors.
- Separate paper, plastic and food waste where facilities exist, and reduce unnecessary printing.
- Remove food waste from shared areas daily to avoid smell and pests.
- The Company encourages respect for the natural environment of Skardu. Employees should set a good example by not littering during field duties.

### 8.3 Meeting Rooms and Shared Facilities

- Book the meeting room in advance using the shared calendar or booking sheet.
- Arrive on time, leave the room clean, and return chairs, whiteboard markers and cables to their place.
- Do not use the meeting room for personal activities.
- Kitchen and pantry areas should be cleaned after use. Wash your own cups and dishes.
- Prayer space or quiet area, if provided, should be kept clean and used with respect for others.

### 8.4 Safe Use of Shared Facilities

- Do not overload electrical sockets or leave heaters, kettles or stoves unattended. This is especially important in winter when heating is in use.
- Take extra care with gas heaters or fuel-burning stoves, and make sure rooms are ventilated to avoid carbon monoxide risk.
- Report faulty switches, leaking taps, broken furniture or blocked exits immediately to the Supervisor.
- Keep corridors, stairs and exits clear at all times.

# 9. Meetings and Workplace Communication

## 9.1 Meeting Preparation and Punctuality

- The person calling a meeting shares the purpose, date, time and agenda in advance, normally at least one working day before.
- Participants read any papers beforehand and arrive on time. Phones should be silent.
- Meetings should start and end on time, and only the people who need to attend should be invited.

## 9.2 Regular Meetings (Proposed)

| Meeting | Frequency | Purpose |
|---|---|---|
| **Team briefing** | Weekly | Review bookings, tasks, deadlines and problems. |
| **Management meeting** | Monthly | Review performance, finances, plans and compliance. |
| **Pre-tour briefing** | Before each tour | Confirm itinerary, safety, roles, contacts and weather. |
| **Post-tour review** | After each tour | Collect feedback, discuss issues and record lessons learned. |

## 9.3 Professional Language and Action Points

- Use polite, clear and respectful language in meetings, calls, messages and emails. Avoid insults, sarcasm or raised voices.
- Listen to others, allow each person to speak, and disagree respectfully.
- At the end of each meeting, summarise decisions and action points, stating who is responsible and the deadline.

## 9.4 Meeting Minutes and Documentation of Decisions

- A nominated note-taker records the date, attendees, key discussion points, decisions and action points.
- Minutes are shared within two working days (proposed) with all participants and the relevant Supervisor.
- The Documentation & Compliance Coordinator stores final minutes in the shared records folder.
- Important decisions made by phone or message should be confirmed by email so there is a written record.

## 9.5 Email and Message Etiquette

- Use official Company email accounts for all business communication.
- Write a clear subject line, a polite greeting, a short message and a closing with your name and job title.
- Check recipients, spelling and attachments before sending. Use “reply all” only when necessary.
- Respond to internal emails within one working day and to client emails as soon as possible (proposed targets).
- Do not send confidential information by personal email or unofficial messaging groups.
- Use an out-of-office message when you are on leave or on a field trip with limited connectivity.

# 10. Use of Office Equipment and Company Resources

## 10.1 Computers and Internet

- Company computers, internet and phones are for business use. Limited and reasonable personal use is allowed if it does not interfere with work.
- Use strong passwords, keep them private and lock your screen when you leave your desk.
- Do not visit unlawful, offensive or unsafe websites, or download unauthorised programs.
- Report suspicious emails, links or computer problems to the Supervisor immediately.
- Back up important work to the approved shared storage regularly.

## 10.2 Official Email and Software

- Employees should use only Company-approved email accounts and communication tools for official work.
- Only licensed or lawfully free software may be installed. Pirated or unlicensed software is not permitted.
- Software purchases and installations must be approved by the CEO or a person authorised by the CEO.

## 10.3 Office Supplies and Company Property

- Use stationery, printing paper and supplies carefully and request new stock from the Finance and Administration team.
- Company property, such as laptops, cameras, radios, power banks, first aid kits and tour equipment, must be signed out and returned in good condition.
- Company property must not be taken out of the office for personal use or lent to others without approval.
- Employees are responsible for reasonable care of the property assigned to them.

## 10.4 Reporting Damaged or Lost Equipment

1. Report the damage or loss to the Supervisor immediately, ideally on the same day.
2. Complete an **Incident / Equipment Report** describing what happened, when and where.
3. The Supervisor informs the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager and, for serious loss or theft, the CEO.
4. The Company reviews the circumstances fairly. Genuine accidents are handled differently from negligence or misuse.
5. Management decides on repair, replacement or other action. Any recovery of costs must follow applicable law and Company policy.

# 11. Work Allocation and Reporting Lines

## 11.1 Reporting Lines (Proposed)

| Level | Role | Reports To |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Owner | — |
| 2 | CEO | Owner |
| 3 | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager; Documentation & Compliance Coordinator | CEO |

| Level | Role | Reports To |
|---|---|---|
| 4 | Department Supervisors | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager (or CEO for operations matters) |
| 5 | Employees | Their Department Supervisor |

### 11.2 Task Assignment and Deadlines

- Supervisors assign tasks clearly, stating the goal, the deadline, the priority and who to contact for help.
- Important tasks should be assigned in writing, by email or the shared task list.
- Employees should confirm they understand the task and raise any problem or workload concern early.
- If a deadline cannot be met, the employee must tell the Supervisor before the deadline, with a reason and a suggested new date.
- Workloads should be shared fairly, taking account of skills, experience and peak-season demand.

### 11.3 Supervisor Responsibilities

- Give clear instructions, support and feedback.
- Check progress regularly and keep records of key assignments.
- Treat team members fairly and avoid favouritism.
- Pass on problems that they cannot solve to the next level.

### 11.4 Escalation of Workplace Issues

If an issue cannot be solved at one level, it should be escalated in order:

| Step | Who | When |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Immediate Supervisor | First point of contact for most work issues. |
| 2 | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager | If the issue is unresolved, involves the Supervisor, or concerns conduct or leave. |
| 3 | CEO | If the issue is serious, unresolved or involves the Manager. |
| 4 | Owner | If the issue involves the CEO or has not been fairly resolved. |

## 12. Health, Safety, and Field Duties

### 12.1 Workplace Safety

- Keep walkways, stairs and exits free of obstructions.
- Know where the first aid kit, fire extinguisher (where provided) and emergency exits are located.
- Report unsafe wiring, heating equipment or damaged furniture immediately.
- Employees who feel unwell should inform their Supervisor and seek medical care.
- The Company should keep a first aid kit and an emergency contact list in the office, to be checked regularly.

### 12.2 Tourism Field Duty Precautions

Skardu and the surrounding region have mountainous terrain, long road journeys, changing weather and limited mobile coverage in some areas. The following precautions are proposed:

- **Planning:** Before each trip, check weather, road and security conditions from reliable and current sources, and confirm that the plan is realistic.
- **Briefing:** Share the itinerary, vehicle details, driver and guide contacts and emergency numbers with the office before departure.
- **Check-ins:** Agree check-in times with the office. Report any change of route or delay.
- **Vehicles:** Use only vehicles and drivers that appear suitable and legally allowed for the route. Do not allow overloading or unsafe driving.
- **Altitude and health:** Be aware of altitude sickness, dehydration, cold and sun exposure. Carry water, basic medicines and a first aid kit.
- **Equipment:** Carry appropriate clothing, charged phones, power banks and any equipment needed for the activity.
- **Clients:** Brief clients on safety rules and local customs. Do not push clients beyond their ability or comfort.
- **Right to stop:** Any employee may recommend delaying or cancelling a trip if conditions are unsafe. The Supervisor decides, and client safety comes before the schedule.
- **Permits:** Check which permits, permissions or registrations are required for the route or activity before the trip, and keep copies. This SOP does not claim any specific permit has been obtained.

### 12.3 Reporting Hazards and Incidents

- Report any hazard, near miss, injury, illness or accident to the Supervisor immediately.
- Complete an **Incident Report** as soon as it is safe to do so, normally within 24 hours (proposed).
- Serious incidents must be reported to the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager and the CEO without delay.
- The Company reviews incidents to find causes and prevent a repeat.

### 12.4 Emergency Procedures

1. **Protect life first.** Move people away from danger and give first aid if trained and safe to do so.
2. **Call for help.** Contact the relevant emergency services and local authorities as appropriate.
3. **Inform the Company.** Call the Supervisor or the CEO and give location, number of people affected and the situation.
4. **Support those affected.** Stay with injured or distressed people and inform their emergency contacts where appropriate.
5. **Record.** Note what happened, the time and actions taken. Do not speak to the media; refer media enquiries to the CEO.
6. **Review.** Management reviews the event and updates procedures where needed.

> **PROPOSED PROJECT ASSUMPTION**
>
> Emergency contact numbers and local emergency service details are not listed here and must be verified and added by management before real use.

# 13. Records and Confidentiality

## 13.1 Records to Be Kept

| Record | Responsible Person | Proposed Storage |
|---|---|---|
| **Attendance registers and field duty logs** | Documentation & Compliance Coordinator | Locked cabinet and secure digital folder |
| **Leave forms and leave register** | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager | Restricted HR folder |
| **Meeting minutes** | Documentation & Compliance Coordinator | Shared records folder |
| **Client information and bookings** | Sales and Marketing / Customer Support | Access-controlled booking system or folder |
| **Incident and equipment reports** | Department Supervisors, filed by the Coordinator | Restricted safety folder |
| **Employee personal files** | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager | Locked cabinet and restricted digital folder |

## 13.2 Secure Storage and Access Permissions

- Records are accessed only by people who need them for their job.
- Paper records are kept in locked cabinets. Digital records are protected by passwords and backed up regularly.
- Leave and personal records are accessible only to the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager, CEO and authorised staff.
- Do not photograph, copy, forward or share records without permission.
- The Coordinator keeps a list of who has access to which records, and updates it when staff change roles or leave.
- Record retention periods should be set by management in line with applicable law.

## 13.3 Client Information and Confidentiality

- Client names, passport or CNIC copies, phone numbers, payment details and travel plans are confidential.
- Collect only the information that is needed for the booking or safety.
- Do not share client information with outsiders except for essential service delivery, such as hotels, transport and permits, or where required by law.
- Do not discuss clients, prices or Company matters in public places or on social media.
- Confidentiality duties continue after an employee leaves the Company.
- Report any suspected data loss or unauthorised access immediately to the Supervisor and the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager.

# 14. Reporting, Escalation, and Corrective Action

## 14.1 How to Report a Concern

Employees are encouraged to raise concerns early and honestly. A report may concern a violation of this SOP, a safety risk, a workplace conflict, harassment, discrimination or other misconduct.

- Report first to your Supervisor, unless the concern involves them.
- Otherwise report to the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager, then the CEO, then the Owner, as described in Section 11.4.
- Reports may be made verbally or in writing. Written reports are preferred for serious matters.
- Reports will be treated with confidentiality as far as practical. Retaliation against anyone who reports in good faith is not allowed.
- Deliberately false reports are themselves a breach of this SOP.

## 14.2 Fair Process

1. **Receive and record.** The report is logged with date, person reporting (if known) and a summary.
2. **Initial review.** The HR / Sales / Marketing Manager (or CEO if the Manager is involved) decides whether the matter needs formal action, informal resolution or urgent safety steps.
3. **Fair investigation.** A person who is not involved in the matter gathers facts, speaks to relevant people and reviews evidence. The process should be prompt, impartial and confidential.
4. **Opportunity to respond.** The employee concerned is told of the allegation and given a fair chance to explain their side and share evidence, before any decision is made. They may be accompanied by a colleague for support (proposed).
5. **Decision.** The CEO, or the Owner if the CEO is involved, decides based on the evidence, and records the reasons.
6. **Corrective action.** Action is taken that is proportionate to the seriousness of the matter and the employee's record.
7. **Appeal.** The employee may request a review of the decision by the next senior level within a set period, such as five working days (proposed).
8. **Record keeping.** Records are kept confidentially in the employee's file.

## 14.3 Proportionate Corrective Action (Proposed)

| Level | Typical Situation (Examples) | Possible Action |
|---|---|---|
| **1 – Informal** | Minor lateness, small lapses in housekeeping | Verbal guidance, noted by Supervisor |
| **2 – Formal warning** | Repeated minor breaches or failure to follow instructions | Written warning and improvement plan |
| **3 – Serious** | Unauthorised absence, careless handling of data, unsafe behaviour | Final written warning, training, change of duties |
| **4 – Gross misconduct** | Harassment, theft, fraud, violence, serious safety breach, deliberate data breach | Suspension during investigation, then possible termination, subject to law |

*Corrective action must follow applicable employment law and the employee's contract. Serious criminal matters may be referred to the relevant authorities.*

# 15. Compliance, Review, and Approval

## 15.1 Employee Compliance

- All employees must read, understand and follow this SOP and sign the Employee Acknowledgement in Section 16.
- New employees receive a copy during induction and sign the acknowledgement within their first week (proposed).
- Supervisors are responsible for making sure their teams follow the SOP.
- Employees who are unsure about a rule should ask their Supervisor or the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager.

## 15.2 Legal Compliance Before Implementation

This document is a project draft. Before any real-world use, the Company must check and apply all applicable employment, labour, tax, safety, data protection, licensing, tourism and other legal requirements for Gilgit-Baltistan and Pakistan, with professional advice where needed. Nothing in this SOP is a statement of legal rights or obligations.

## 15.3 Review and Revision Control

- The Document Owner (HR / Sales / Marketing Manager) reviews this SOP at least once a year. The proposed next review date is **21 October 2027**.
- An earlier review may happen after a major incident, change in law or business change.
- Proposed changes are sent to the Documentation & Compliance Coordinator, who updates the draft and records the change in the Version History.
- Minor edits increase the version by 0.1 (for example, 1.1). Major changes increase the version number (for example, 2.0).
- Only the latest approved version may be used. Old versions are marked “Superseded” and archived.

## 15.4 Approval Requirements

This SOP becomes effective only after it has been prepared, reviewed and approved as shown in Section 17. Revised versions require the same three approvals.

# 16. Employee Acknowledgement

I confirm that I have received, read and understood the General Office Standard Operating Procedure (EST-OPS-SOP-001, Version 1.0) of Explore Skardu Tours. I understand that I must follow it and that I may ask my Supervisor or the HR / Sales / Marketing Manager if anything is unclear. I understand that failure to follow it may lead to corrective action under Section 14.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Employee Name** | |
| **Job Title / Department** | |
| **Signature** | |
| **Date** | |

## 17. Approval Table

The names, signatures and dates below are intentionally left blank. They must be completed by the responsible persons when this document is formally reviewed and approved.

| Action | Role | Signature | Date |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Prepared By** | Documentation & Compliance Coordinator | | |
| **Reviewed By** | HR / Sales / Marketing Manager | | |
| **Approved By** | CEO / Owner | | |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Document ID** | EST-OPS-SOP-001 |
| **Version** | 1.0 |
| **Effective Date** | 21 October 2026 |
| **Review Date** | 21 October 2027 |
| **Status** | Draft for Academic Project Review |

**FINAL NOTE**

This SOP was prepared as part of an academic assignment for a proposed business. It contains no registration numbers, certifications, employee names or signatures. All proposed assumptions must be verified, and legal requirements checked, before real-world implementation.